

Chapter 36-7

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After hesitating for a long time, Xu Qingzhu still picked up Liang Shi's phone with trembling hands.

The lock screen password was Liang Shi's birthday, which she easily unlocked.

Then she clicked into the memo app—it was completely blank.

There was also her WeChat, which had very few contacts, completely different from Liang Shi's previous WeChat where she could casually call upon friends at will.

Even though Xu Qingzhu had never checked Liang Shi's phone before, she had inadvertently glimpsed it, and her contact list had at least over a thousand people.

But the current account was simple and clean, just like her processed social media feed.

Xu Qingzhu still couldn't find any clues.

This was her first time doing such a thing. Her palms were sweaty and trembling. In the end, she didn't know what she accidentally clicked on, but it brought up an encrypted folder.

She didn't know how many digits the password was.

Xu Qingzhu first entered Liang Shi's birthday—incorrect.

She then entered her own birthday—also incorrect.

After that, she tried some other dates that were relatively important to Liang Shi, but none of them worked.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly thought of their wedding anniversary.

So she entered that string of numbers, but it was still incorrect.

She had already given up. When she was about to exit, there was a reminder: it's two dates added together.

So she tried Liang Shi's birthday plus her own birthday, then tried Liang Shi's birthday plus their wedding anniversary.

Both were wrong.

Without much hope, she entered her own birthday plus their wedding anniversary.

...And it opened.

Xu Qingzhu was shocked beyond belief. She never would have expected it to be this string of numbers.

She didn't have time to think too much about it and quickly opened the folder. One after another, they were all empty documents, like nesting dolls¹. When she clicked to the very end, there was only one photo.

—It was an extremely dim room that emanated a ghostly red glow. The ceiling was arched, somewhat resembling a coffin lid. On the floor of the room were rows of unlit white candles, the bed was covered with a layer of hell money², and the person in the photo wore an oversized white mourning dress, sitting in the middle of the bed. Those eyes stared at the camera with an empty and lifeless gaze, lips parted to reveal white teeth in a bone-chillingly terrifying smile.

The base tone was dark, but the center was white.

And in the bottom right corner of this photo were two words—Sacrificial Offering.

The person in the photo was Liang Shi, but much more immature than now.

She should have been quite young.

Xu Qingzhu broke out in a cold sweat from fright.

"Why are you here?" Liang Shi's voice suddenly rang out, accompanied by the sound of the bathroom door closing.

Xu Qingzhu was startled and immediately switched the phone back to the main interface, then said, "Your... your phone was left outside, I... I helped bring it in for you."

"You could have just brought it in," Liang Shi said puzzledly, "Why are you so nervous?"

"I'm not... not..." Xu Qingzhu almost bit her tongue off. She swallowed, "You should... sleep early. I'm going upstairs. Good night."

After saying this, without waiting for Liang Shi to respond, she rushed out of the room like a gust of wind, not forgetting to close the door behind her.

And Liang Shi's memory certainly wasn't that poor.

She had come in playing with her phone after dinner.

So obviously, Xu Qingzhu had just checked her phone.

But the problem was that she had already cleared everything. There were pitifully few apps on her phone, and she had even deleted those few sentences from the original owner's memo.

She opened her phone and checked the recently opened applications.

Then she saw that photo.

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This was Liang Shi's first time seeing it.

The first glance at the photo startled her, because that person with a face identical to her teenage self was sitting in the middle of the bed, showing a sinister smile, like a puppet being controlled by someone.

It was horrifying enough to belong in a horror movie.

But there was only this one photo on the phone, nothing else.

Liang Shi saved it, then exited and tried to open that folder again, only to discover it was encrypted.

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She had to admire Xu Qingzhu.

And that night, Liang Shi had another dream.

In the dream were too many bizarre scenes, but what left the deepest impression on her was the small bamboo house in the mountains.

It was a rather beautiful mountain, with lush green grass on the mountainside and a clear stream at the foot of the mountain. The stream water wound around the base of the mountain, nourishing the creatures living on the mountain.

From the foot of the mountain all the way up, at the halfway point stood a lonely small bamboo house. Inside the bamboo house sat a middle-aged man wearing blue-green robes with a very long beard.

Qiu Zimin pulled the young Liang Shi to the middle-aged man, "Sir, how do you think this person's qualifications are?"

"Passable," the other party said.

And the young Liang Shi was left outside the bamboo house.

From inside the bamboo house came the sound of Qiu Zimin and the middle-aged man conversing.

"If I turn her into a sacrificial offering, it will make the Liang family prosperous and successful?" Qiu Zimin asked.

The middle-aged man said, "Isn't she your daughter? Are you willing to give her up?"

Footnotes: ¹ Nesting dolls: Refers to Russian matryoshka dolls that nest inside one another, used metaphorically here to describe folders within folders ² Hell money: Paper money burned as offerings to deceased ancestors in Chinese traditional beliefs, also known as "ghost money" or "spirit money"